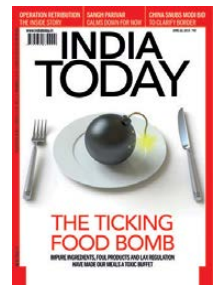
FROM THE

EDITOR-IN-CHIEF

The world and India are not short of problems. War, regime change, elections, corruption scandals, we have all of that running in spate. What, then, is a humble laddoo, you may ask. Well, in India, anything that relates to religion is highly inflammable material. Moreover, this is not just another laddoo from the neighbourhood *halwai*. The sweet that has soured the air recently is the sacred *prasadam* you get at Tirupati. This temple in Andhra Pradesh is a giant magnet for Hindu pilgrims across the land, drawing an astounding 30-40 million devotees annually. Therefore, national headlines were dominated for days by a question that may stump outsiders: was ghee contaminated with animal fat used in the Tirupati laddoo? It got so much traction after Chief Minister Chandrababu Naidu aired the speculation, targeting his predecessor Y.S. Jagan Mohan Reddy, that the Supreme Court was forced to issue a stern admonition to "keep gods away from politics". Noble sentiments, but shall we say—fat chance?

Politics in Andhra Pradesh has naturally been set on high flame with the controversy, but this is not an issue restricted to the coastal state. Ghee is one of the most consecrated of 'pure' sattvik food elements in Hinduism, and the idea of it being adulterated with animal fat struck a raw nerve so far afield that the prasad at Ayodhya's new Ram temple and Odisha's centuries-old Puri Jagannath was sent for purity tests. The hallowed Badrinath and Kedarnath shrines in Uttarakhand, too, devised new rules to ensure blemish-free prasad. In a way, the laddoo has become a lightning rod amid a storm of deep political emotions. At one level, it feeds into the heated debate on whether governments should at all have a presence in temple administrations. The Tirumala Tirupati Devasthanams (TTD), the richest Hindu temple board in the world with a net worth of $36 billion (Rs 3.02 lakh crore), is, for instance, nominally an 'independent' trust, but under the state government. At a more 'people' level, the subject caught fire because the social field has been kept supercharged with a larger politics of 'purity' around food that seems to be sweeping India, beginning from Uttar Pradesh and reaching Himachal Pradesh and Maharashtra.



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Tirupati, which sees daily footfalls of anywhere between 60,000 and 100,000 on special days, doles out 300,000 laddoos daily. This requires an eye-popping 15 tonnes of cow ghee. The present row began with the TTD sending samples for testing to a laboratory run by the National Dairy Development Board in Gujarat. Doubts had gradually crept in about the quality of ghee with the entry of new suppliers, brought in after verification norms were tweaked and made less rigorous in 2019-20. Among them was a private supplier from Dindigul, Tamil Nadu, which charged only Rs 320 for a kilo of ghee. In July, the TTD authorities rejected four tankers of ghee from it and blacklisted the firm. The lab report clearly indicated adulteration but was inconclusive about the actual adulterant. It listed as possibilities a whole series of vegetable oils but also beef tallow and pork lard.

The fat, as they say, was in the fire. CM Naidu went to town with the news, alleging sacrilege and tracing it to changes in ghee procurement rules during Jagan's regime. What's more, Naidu connected it to Jagan being a practising Christian. Jagan had vowed to visit Tirumala "to atone for the sins of Naidu". But he had to pull out after the CM taunted him saying he should formally declare his belief in the presiding deity, and hence Hinduism, before entering Tirupati. The third factor in Andhra politics, the actor and deputy CM Pawan Kalyan whose Jana Sena Party is close to the BJP, meanwhile, went on penance at another Venkateswara temple and rounded that off with a trek up the Seven Hills of Tirumala alongside ordinary pilgrims. Kalyan, who seems to foresee a Hindutva future ahead of him as a Trojan horse for the BJP in Andhra politics, also ratcheted up emotions against government control of temples. He proposed a national-level 'Sanatana Dharma Rakshana Board' to prevent "desecration" and protect "dharmic practices".

Senior Deputy Editor Amarnath K. Menon, close to all the action in Hyderabad, brings you a complete 360-degree darshan of this episode of religion adulterated with politics. Thickening the plot is another curious apparition. It is the 'Aum' certificate for shops at pilgrim centres in Maharashtra, meant to denote that the vendor is not a Muslim and hence that the goods are not "defiled". Senior Associate Editor Dhaval S. Kulkarni reports on this from Trimbakeshwar temple in Nashik. Associate Editor Ashish Misra fills in from Uttar Pradesh, which had been the original ground zero for all the alarm created over 'food purity'. In July, a directive from the Yogi Adityanath government for shopkeepers to display their names during the Kanwar Yatra had earned a rap on the knuckles from the Supreme Court. But the Yogi regime has issued fresh directives along the same lines, initiating a state-level drive.

In our democracy, everyone has the right to believe and practise their religion as they deem right. The true test of our spiritual heritage, however, is not to be consumed by fear and loathing but to let faith be the road to fellowship and serenity.

(Aroon Purie)